FORM YOUR TEAM

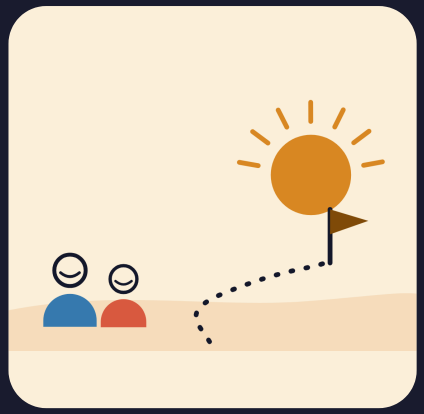
The Form Your Team Playbook

Six conversations that turn a group of people into a team. A practical guide for team leads, managers and informal leaders.



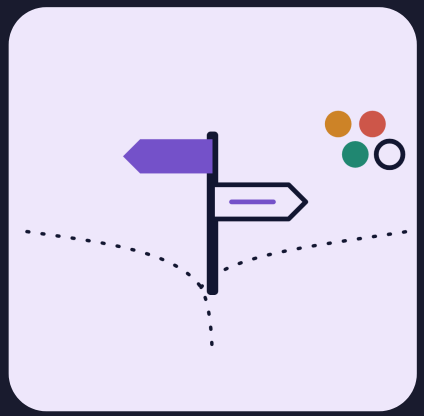
By Michael Heider
14+ years of facilitating teams and leaders

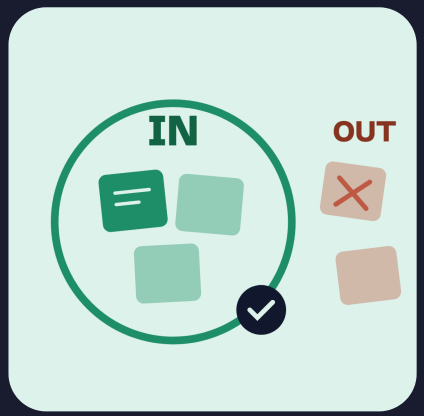
FACILITATOR PLAYBOOK · INCLUDES PRINTABLE CANVASES













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Michael Heider
14+ years facilitating teams and leaders, at the LEGO Group, Grundfos, Viessmann and in his own workshops

HELLO

Great teams are formed, not found

For more than 14 years I have worked with teams and leaders on how they work together, at the LEGO Group, Grundfos and Viessmann, and in my own workshops. One thing keeps coming back.

The teams that work well have rarely just been lucky. At some point they sat down and talked properly: about why they exist, who they are, how they work and decide, and what they expect of each other.

Most people who lead a team know these conversations matter. What is usually missing is a simple way to run them, without it feeling awkward or turning into another meeting. That is what this playbook gives you.

You don't need facilitation experience. You need a team, a little time, and the willingness to ask questions you don't already know the answers to.

Teams are not built once. They are continuously formed and re-formed.

Michael Heider

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

Read once, then pick one conversation

1 **Read the first part once**
It covers your role, how to prepare and the few moves that make any session work. About 15 minutes.

2 **Pick one conversation**
Use the signs on page 5, or start where it hurts. You don't need to do all six at once.

3 **Run the exercise**
Each conversation has one exercise, step by step, with what you can say and what to do when it gets tricky.

4 **Hand out the team workbook**
Everyone in the room gets the free team workbook from formyourteam.dk, with the questions, the steps and a worksheet for each exercise. This playbook is for you.

5 **Write it on the canvas**
Print the canvases at the back of this book, or use the free Miro template. The canvas is your team's shared memory.

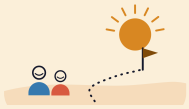
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THE IDEA

Six conversations every team needs

Each one opens with a few key questions, uses one exercise to give the team a structure to think and talk, and ends with something written on the team canvas. There is no fixed order.



1

Why are we here?



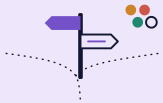
2

Who are we?



3

How do we work?



4

How do we make decisions?



5

How do we want to be together?



6

How do we learn and reform?

WHERE TO START

Start where it hurts

A new team usually starts with Why and Who. An existing team starts with the conversation it needs most. Which of these sound familiar?

1 · Why are we here?

- People describe the team's job very differently
- The team says yes to almost everything

2 · Who are we?

- New people have joined
- People rarely ask each other for help

3 · How do we work?

- A full calendar, but unclear priorities
- "We should have talked about this earlier"

4 · How do we make decisions?

- The same topic keeps coming back
- "Who decided this?" more often than "why?"

5 · How do we want to be together?

- Unspoken rules that only some people know
- Frustration that comes out in side conversations

6 · How do we learn and reform?

- Someone has joined or left
- Priorities or the purpose have shifted

Not sure? Take the free two-minute team health check on **formyourteam.dk**, and ask two teammates to take it too.

PART 1

Your role

Running these conversations with your own team means leading and facilitating at the same time. A few simple habits make the difference between a meeting people endure and a conversation that changes how they work.



Wearing two hats

As the leader you have opinions, responsibility and power. As the facilitator your job is to help the team think together, so every voice is heard. Not just the loudest one, and not just yours.

1 Speak last

When the leader speaks first, the conversation is over. Ask the question, wait, and add your view at the end as one view among others. One exception: when you ask people to share something personal, go first. You show how open it is safe to be.

2 Name the hat you're wearing

"Now I'm taking off my facilitator hat for a moment, and speaking as your manager." It feels formal the first time, and it helps people a lot.

3 Say what is open and what is not

"We decide this together" and "I decide, but I want your input" are both fine. Inviting people to shape something and then overruling them is not.

4 Know when to hand over

If the topic is about you, your leadership or a conflict you are part of, ask a colleague, HR or an outside facilitator to guide it. Then you can take part fully.

Before the session

Good sessions are won before they start. Prepare three things.

1

The purpose

Finish this sentence before you invite anyone:

“After this session, we will have…”

For example: “…a first version of our purpose statement.” If you can’t finish it, you’re not ready to invite people yet.

2

The invitation

“We’ve been busy delivering, and we’ve never really talked about how we want to work together. I’d like us to spend two hours on that. No preparation needed, just come curious.”

Short, human and honest. Never make it sound like a fix for a problem person.

3

The room

- A room with wall space, chairs in a circle or horseshoe
- The canvases printed big, A3 or larger
- The free team workbook, one copy per person
- Online: the Miro template, tested beforehand
- Protected time: no laptops, no “I’ll join for the first half”

Open, hold, close

Every session has three phases, each with a few simple moves. If you remember only one thing: protect the last ten minutes.

Open

Check in

"In one word, how do you arrive today?" Every voice in the room early.

Say why you're here

What you'll do, and what you'll have at the end.

Agree one or two ground rules

"Phones away." "We listen to understand, not to reply."

Hold

Write before talking

Two or three quiet minutes on post-its first. More ideas, and quieter people get a fair chance.

Use rounds

Everyone shares one thing, instead of the same three people talking.

Keep time, out loud

"We have ten minutes left for this part." Park side topics on a "later" sheet.

Close

Read back what you agreed

"Is there anything on here you can't live with?"

Agree who writes it up

And when you'll look at it again.

Check out

"What do you take with you?" Protect the last ten minutes.

Make it safe to be honest

These conversations only work if people say what they actually think. As the leader, you have more influence on that than anyone else in the room.



1. **Start low-risk, then build up**
   Not “What’s wrong with how we work?” but “What’s one thing that went well this month?”

2. **Write first, and allow anonymity**
   Post-its collected and read out by you let people say what they wouldn’t say out loud.

3. **Watch your own reaction**
   When someone criticises, especially you, say “Thank you, tell me more.” Your reaction to the first critical comment decides whether there will be a second.

4. **Name the silence**
   “It’s quiet. What would someone who disagrees say?”

5. **Follow through**
   If people speak up and nothing changes, they stop. Every agreement you act on makes the next conversation more honest.

CONVERSATION 1

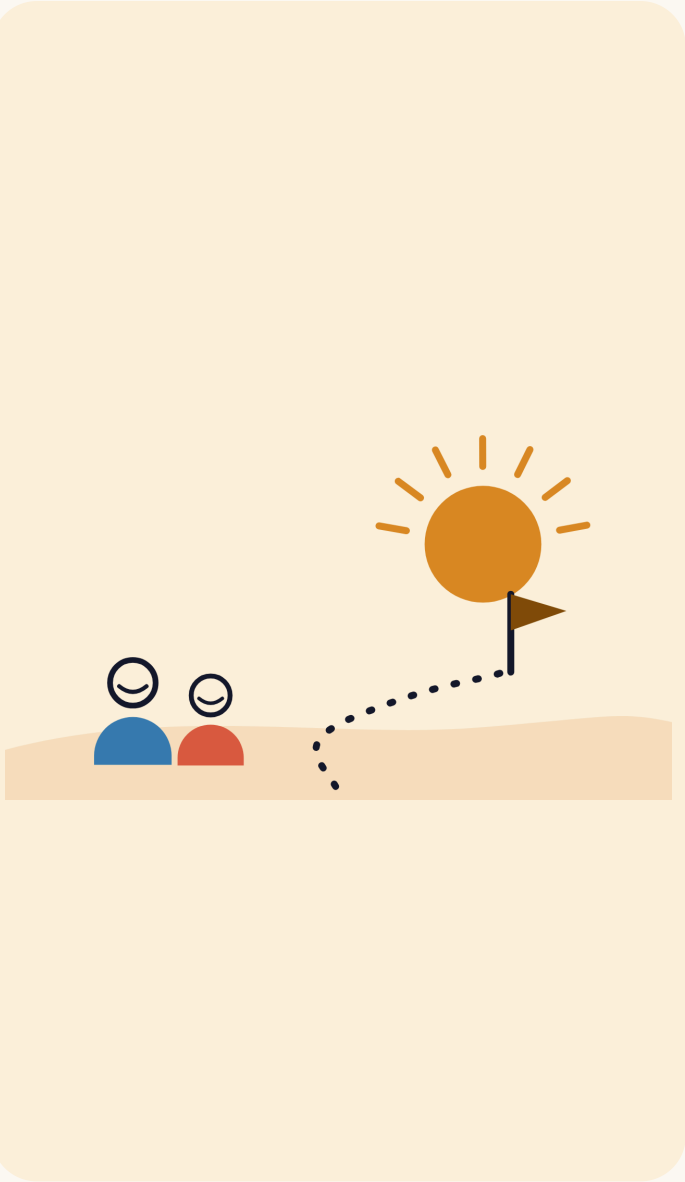
Why are we here?

A purpose the whole team can say out loud, in plain words, makes every later conversation easier. It helps you say yes to the right things, and no to the rest.

Who benefits from our work?

What difference should the team make for them?

What would meaningful success look like?



ON THE CANVAS

A purpose statement: "We exist to… for… so that…", and a picture of success in three years.

Also in this conversation: In three years' time… (40 min, canvas on page 30).

CONVERSATION 1 · THE EXERCISE

Explain it to a friend

Pairs, then whole team · 35 min

Find plain, human words for why the team exists, before anyone writes a mission statement.

1. **In pairs, imagine explaining the team's reason for being to a friend over dinner. Speak naturally and avoid organisational language.**

   "Explain our team the way you would to a good friend at dinner."

2. **The listener does not correct or debate. They capture phrases that feel clear, human and meaningful.**

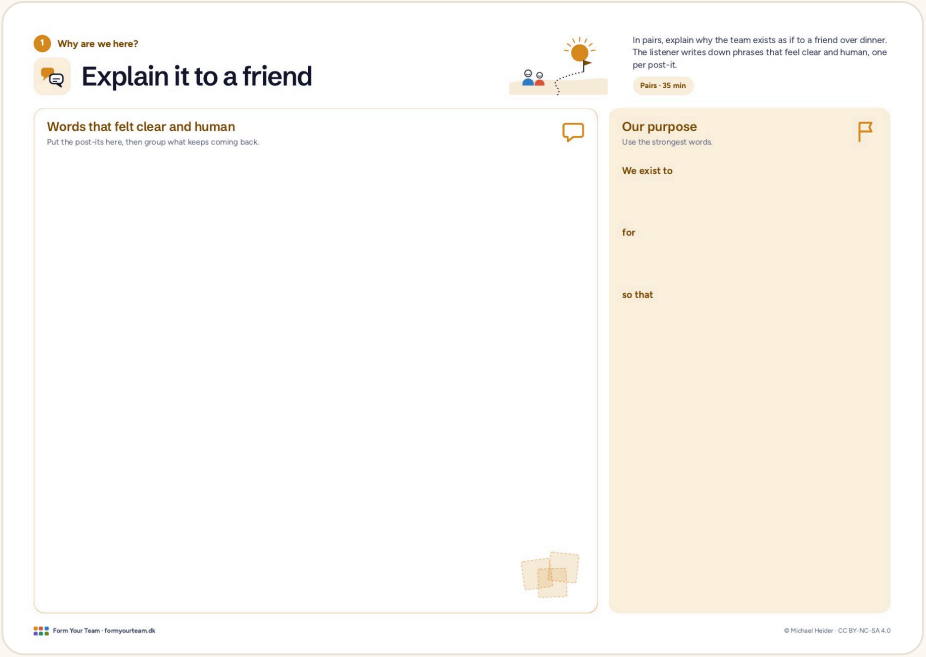
   "Listeners: only write down phrases that sound clear and human."

3. **Switch roles, then compare what was consistent and what was different.**

   "What was the same? What surprised you?"

4. **Use the strongest language to create a shared purpose statement.**

   "Good enough for now. We can polish the words later."



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 29**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

The group gets stuck on wording

"We have the meaning. The words can be polished later." Ask two volunteers to bring back two versions after the break.

CONVERSATION 2

Who are we?

Teams work better when people know each other beyond job titles. Share enough to work well together. Nobody has to share more than they want to.

What does each person bring?

How do we each work at our best?

What should teammates know about us beyond our role?



ON THE CANVAS

The team's strengths, what it wants to develop, and how each person works at their best.

Also in this conversation: The story behind me (4–5 min per person) and Skills marketplace (40 min, canvas on page 32).

CONVERSATION 2 · THE EXERCISE

Personal user manual

Individual, then share in pairs · 25 min

Make working preferences explicit, so teammates don't have to guess.

1. **Each person completes their own card on their own, in their own words.**

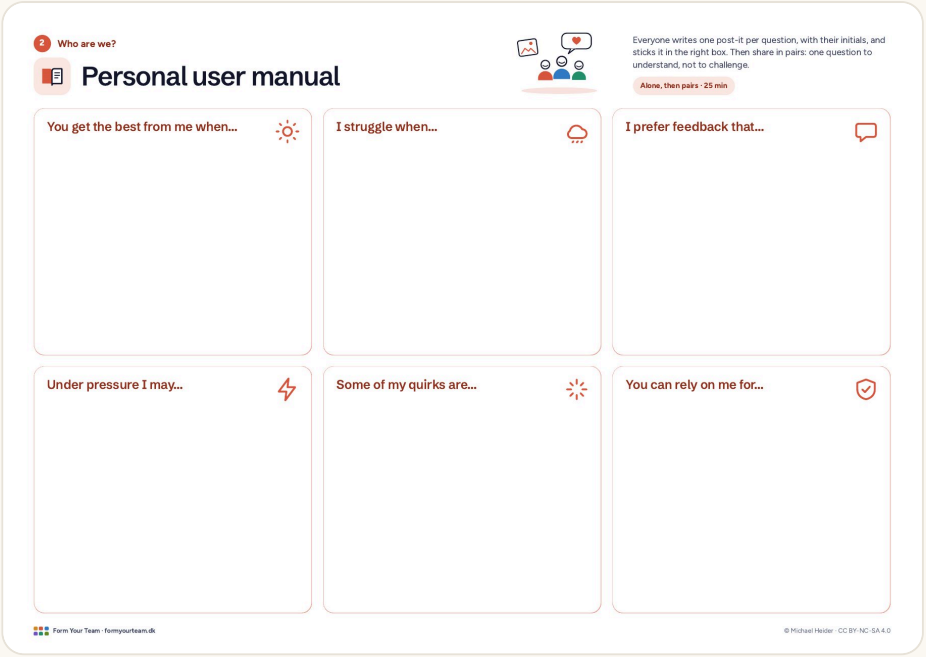
   "One post-it per prompt. Share what you're comfortable with." Go first yourself, and be honest about the pressure one.

2. **Share in pairs. The listener asks one question to understand better, not to challenge.**

   "Ask one question to understand, not to challenge."

3. **Bring one surprising or useful insight back to the whole team.**

   "Not the whole manual. Just one thing you learned."



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 31**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

Answers stay on the surface

"And when it really matters, what helps you do your best work?" Or share a deeper answer of your own.

CONVERSATION 3

How do we work?

Most teams never decide how they work. Their calendar just fills up. Agree when you plan, when you make and when you review, and drop the rest.

When do we plan, make and review?

Which meetings and habits actually help us, and which can go?

What should we do together, and what can happen on our own time?



ON THE CANVAS

When and how you plan, make and review, and the meetings and habits you drop.

CONVERSATION 3 · THE EXERCISE

Draw your team's loop

Whole team, at a whiteboard · 40 min

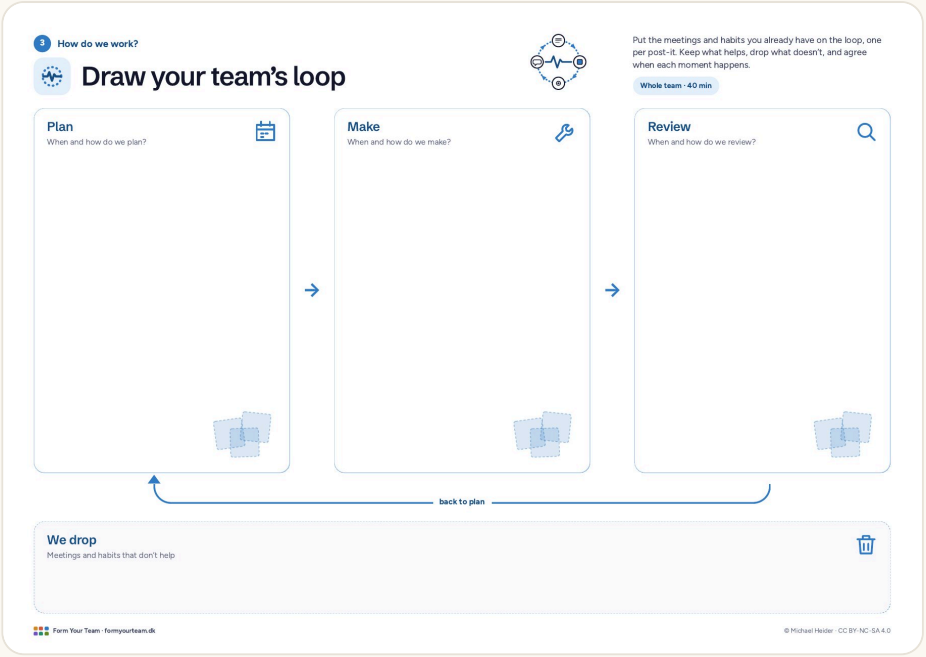
Agree a simple rhythm for planning, making and reviewing.

1. **Draw a loop: plan → make → review → back to plan.**
   "Every team goes through this loop, whether they plan it or not."

2. **Put the meetings and habits you already have on the loop. Keep what helps, drop what doesn't.**
   "One per post-it. Include the informal ones." Then: "What do you notice?"

3. **For each of the three moments, agree when and how it happens, and write it above.**
   "What problem was this meeting solving?"

4. **Try the rhythm for one working cycle, then adjust it together.**
   "Let's try this for one cycle, then look at it again."



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 33**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

The meeting nobody likes but nobody can drop

"How can we make it cost us less?" Often it can become a short written update.

CONVERSATION 4

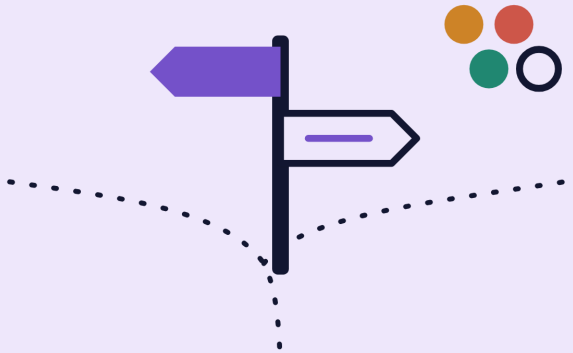
How do we make decisions?

There is more than one way to decide. Most friction comes from decisions that are made differently every time, or not at all. Pick one you make often, and choose how.

Which decisions can individuals make?

Which decisions need input or shared ownership?

Which ways of deciding could we try?



ON THE CANVAS

For the decisions that come up often: who decides, who is asked, who is told, and how.

CONVERSATION 4 · THE EXERCISE

Choose how to decide

Whole team · 40 min

Pick one important decision you make often, and choose a way to make it next time.

1. **Each person names decisions that come up again and again. Agree on one that matters to the team.**

   "One per post-it. Small decisions count too."

2. **Read the twelve ways to decide together. Ask what this decision needs: narrowing options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say.**

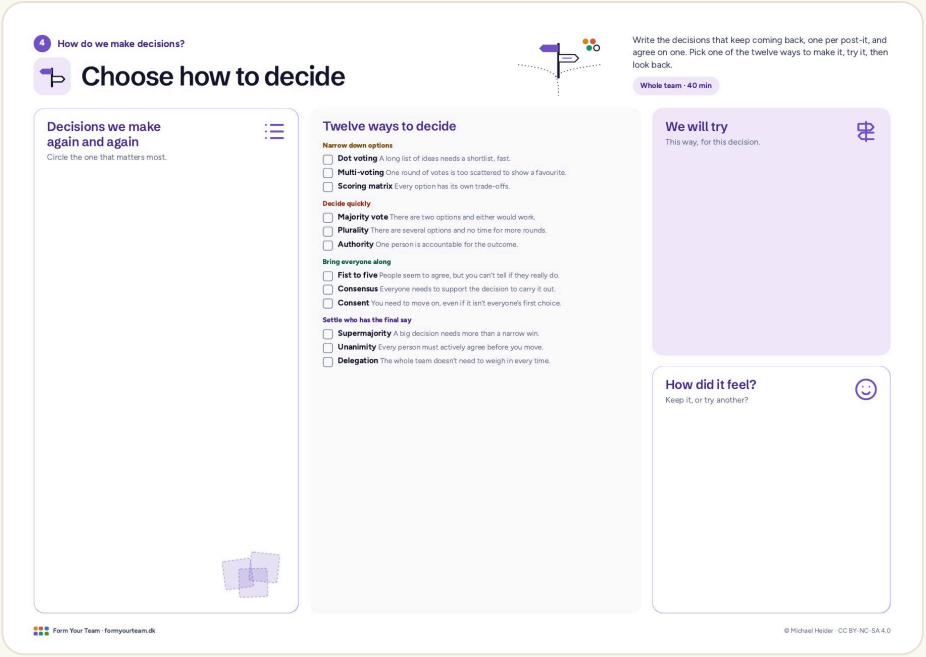
   "Does this need narrowing down, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say?"

3. **Choose one way and try it the next few times the decision comes up.**

   "Could someone new read this and know what to do?"

4. **Talk about how it felt, and whether to keep it or try another.**

   "How did it feel? Keep it, or try another?"



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 34**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

"But you're the manager, you decide."

Say which decisions you keep and which you hand over. Then really hand them over.

CONVERSATION 5

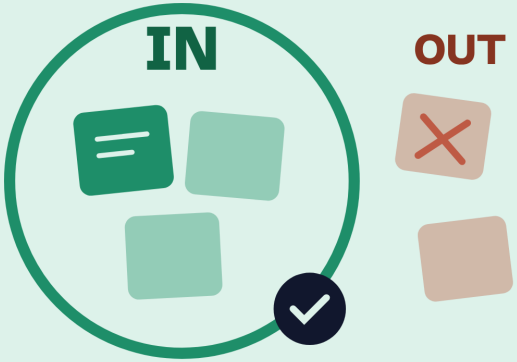
How do we want to be together?

Agreements only help if you can see when they are kept or broken. Write behaviours someone could observe, not values on a poster.

What behaviour helps us do our best work?

What behaviour is not acceptable in this team?

How will we hold ourselves and each other accountable?



ON THE CANVAS

Five to eight behaviours that belong in the team (IN), and the ones that don't (OUT).

CONVERSATION 5 · THE EXERCISE

The two-circle team contract

Whole team · 60 min

Agree, in plain words, the behaviours that belong in this team and the ones that don't.

1. **Draw two large circles and label them IN and OUT.**
   "Think of a moment when this team was at its best. What were people doing?"

2. **Add behaviours to IN that the team wants to practise and protect.**
   "Start with a verb."

3. **Add behaviours to OUT that undermine trust, inclusion or good work.**
   "Behaviours, not people."

4. **Talk them through, combine similar ones, and rewrite them as things someone could actually see.**
   "Could you tell if someone is doing this?"



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 36**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

Everyone writes "respect" and "openness"

Ask: "What does that look like on a Tuesday?" "Be respectful" becomes "No laptops when someone presents."

CONVERSATION 6

How do we learn and reform?

Your canvas is a first version. Teams change, so decide now when you will look at it again, and what kind of change should send you back to the start.

What should we protect?

What is no longer serving the team?

What change should trigger a team reset?



ON THE CANVAS

What to keep, what to change, one or two small experiments, and what should make you sit down with the canvas again.

CONVERSATION 6 · THE EXERCISE

Keep / Change / Try

Whole team · 40 min

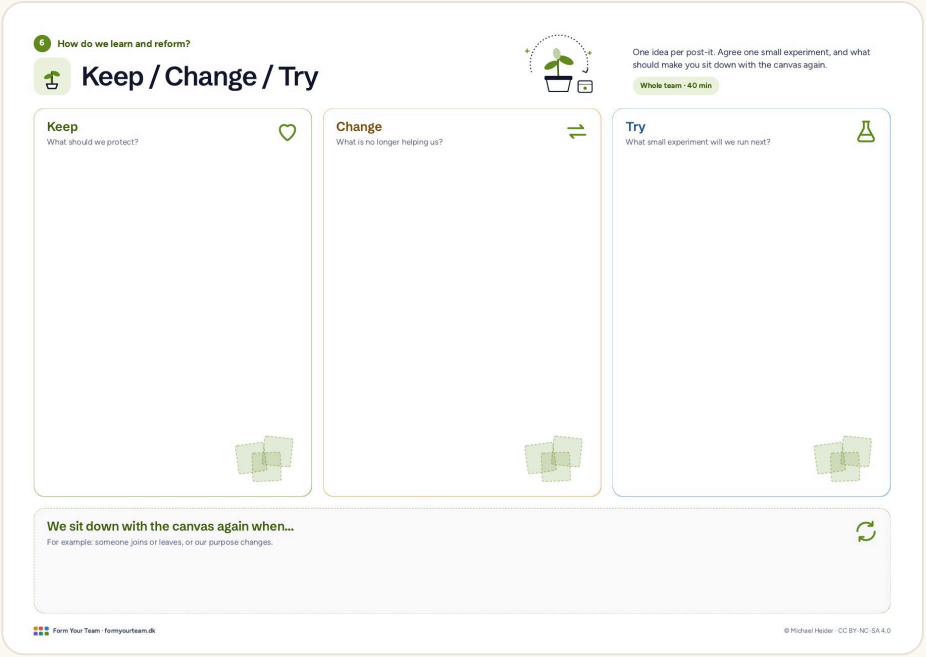
Decide what to protect, what to let go and what small experiment to run next.

1. **Keep: What about this team should we protect?**
   "What about this team should we protect?" Start with Keep on purpose.

2. **Change: What is no longer helping us?**
   "What is no longer helping us?"

3. **Try: What small experiment will we run next?**
   "What small experiment will we run next?" Push for small and concrete.

4. **Agree what should make you sit down with the canvas again, for example someone joining or leaving, or the purpose changing.**
   "What should make us sit down with the canvas again?"



The canvas for this exercise · print it A3 or use the Miro template **page 37**

WHEN IT GETS TRICKY

The experiments stay vague

"Communicate better" is not an experiment. "For the next four weeks, we end every meeting by writing down who does what" is.

Plan your series

One workshop day

All six in one day, often away from the office. Builds energy and a strong shared experience. Intense, and the later conversations often get less attention than they deserve.

A series

Recommended

One conversation every week or two, in 90–120 minute sessions. Fits a normal calendar, gives people time to reflect, and lets you test agreements before the next one. What I recommend for most teams.

A typical series

WEEK 1	WEEK 2–3	WEEK 5	WEEK 7	WEEK 9	AFTER ~3 MONTHS
Why are we here?	Who are we?	How do we work?	How do we make decisions?	How do we want to be together?	How do we learn and reform?

Plan the next session before you end the current one. If the next date isn't in the calendar when people leave the room, it often doesn't happen.

After the session

Most teams have good conversations. Few capture what they agreed in a way they come back to.

1. **Write it up within a day**
   Just the canvas and a short list of agreements. Put it where people see it.

2. **Use it**
   Check the decision rules, walk new joiners through it, point to the contract.

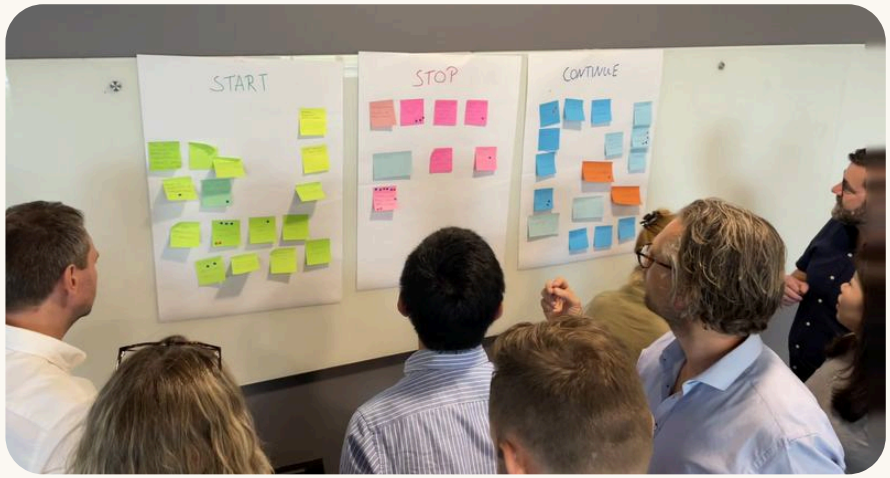
3. **Follow up in your normal meetings**
   Two minutes: “How are we doing with what we agreed?”

4. **Notice what changes**
   “What’s different since we had this conversation?” Celebrate the small things.

When to bring in someone else

Ask a colleague, HR or an outside facilitator to guide the conversation when:

- The topic is about you or your leadership
- Trust in the team is low
- The stakes are high, like a merger or a reorganisation
- You want to take part fully, as a team member



CHEAT SHEET

The six conversations on one page

	CONVERSATION	EXERCISE	TIME
1	**Why are we here?**	Explain it to a friend	35 min
2	**Who are we?**	Personal user manual	25 min
3	**How do we work?**	Draw your team's loop	40 min
4	**How do we make decisions?**	Choose how to decide	40 min
5	**How do we want to be together?**	The two-circle team contract	60 min
6	**How do we learn and reform?**	Keep / Change / Try	40 min

WHAT NEXT

Ready to run your first conversation?

Pick one conversation, book the room, and send the invitation this week. If you want more help, here is where to find it.

THE VIDEO COURSE

Run the six conversations with confidence

29 short lessons with a session plan for every conversation, what to say, and how to handle the tricky moments. Plus a printable facilitator guidebook and a template pack.

Your two free lessons are waiting in your inbox.

formyourteam.dk/course

FREE TOOLS

The website and Miro template

Fill in the canvas together online, take the team health check, download the workbook, or copy the board for remote sessions.

formyourteam.dk
The Miro template

WORK WITH ME

Bring in an outside facilitator

Team development workshops, innovation sprints and strategy processes, tailored to where your team is.

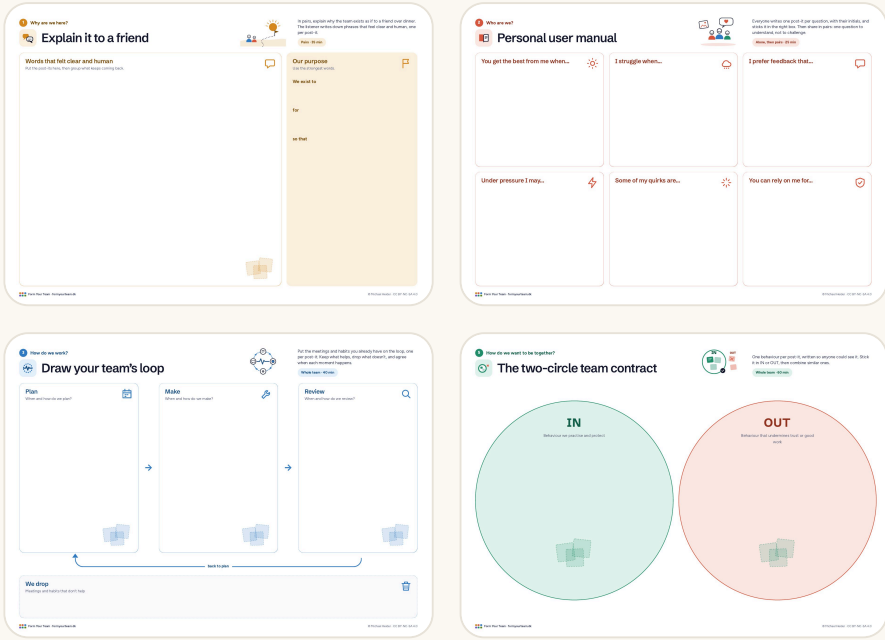
formyourteam.dk/work
michael@formyourteam.dk

THE CANVASES

Print them big

On the next pages: the team canvas, one canvas for each exercise, and the twelve ways to decide. They print best on A3 or larger. Put them on the wall, and write on post-its so you can move things around.

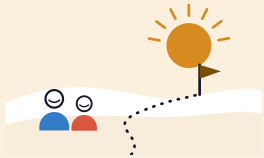
Working remotely? Use the free Miro template instead.



Form Your Team

Our Team Canvas

Six conversations every team needs, in any order. Each one answers a few questions, and together they become your Team Canvas.



1 Why are we here?

Our purpose

- Why do we exist?
- Who do we do this for, and how?

Our future

- What does success look like in three years?
- How will we know it is becoming real?



2 Who are we?

Our people

- What does each person bring?
- What do we want to develop?
- How do we each work at our best?



3 How do we work?

Our rhythm

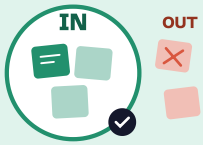
- When do we plan, make and review?
- What do we do together, and what on our own time?



4 How do we make decisions?

Our decision making

- Which decision do we make often?
- Which way of deciding will we try?



5 How do we want to be together?

Our team values

- What behaviour helps us do our best work?
- What behaviour is not acceptable?

IN OUT



6 How do we learn and reform?

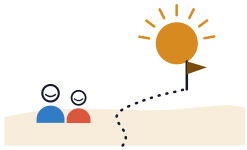
Our next evolution

- What will we keep, change and try?
- What would make us reset this canvas?

Exercises for every conversation at formyourteam.dk · © Michael Heider · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

1 Why are we here?

Explain it to a friend



In pairs, explain why the team exists as if to a friend over dinner. The listener writes down phrases that feel clear and human, one per post-it.

Pairs · 35 min

Words that felt clear and human

Put the post-its here, then group what keeps coming back.

Our purpose

Use the strongest words.

We exist to

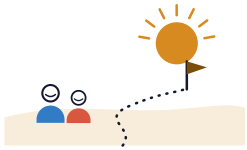
for

so that

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1 Why are we here?

In three years' time...



Everyone writes two or three endings to the sentence, one per post-it. Group similar ones, then vote for the one that feels true, not just ambitious.

Alone, then together · 40 min

In three years' time, this team will have...

Post-its here. Group them, then give everyone three dots to vote.

Our picture of success

The one we chose, refined together.

Signs it is becoming real

Two or three things we would notice.

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2 Who are we?

Personal user manual



Everyone writes one post-it per question, with their initials, and sticks it in the right box. Then share in pairs: one question to understand, not to challenge.

Alone, then pairs · 25 min

You get the best from me when...

I struggle when...

I prefer feedback that...

Under pressure I may...

Some of my quirks are...

You can rely on me for...

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2 Who are we?

Skills marketplace



Everyone writes three things they can offer and one they want to grow in, with their initials. Read them out, then pair people up.

Alone, then together · 40 min

I can offer

Three post-its each.

I want to grow in

One post-it each.

Pairs to try

Who learns from whom in the next few weeks?

_____ ↔ _____ _____ ↔ _____ _____ ↔ _____ _____ ↔ _____

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3 How do we work?

Draw your team's loop



Put the meetings and habits you already have on the loop, one per post-it. Keep what helps, drop what doesn't, and agree when each moment happens.

Whole team · 40 min

Plan

When and how do we plan?

Make

When and how do we make?

Review

When and how do we review?

back to plan

We drop

Meetings and habits that don't help

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4 How do we make decisions?

Choose how to decide



Write the decisions that keep coming back, one per post-it, and agree on one. Pick one of the twelve ways to make it, try it, then look back.

Whole team · 40 min

Decisions we make again and again

Circle the one that matters most.



Twelve ways to decide

Narrow down options

- [ ] **Dot voting** A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.
- [ ] **Multi-voting** One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.
- [ ] **Scoring matrix** Every option has its own trade-offs.

Decide quickly

- [ ] **Majority vote** There are two options and either would work.
- [ ] **Plurality** There are several options and no time for more rounds.
- [ ] **Authority** One person is accountable for the outcome.

Bring everyone along

- [ ] **Fist to five** People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.
- [ ] **Consensus** Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.
- [ ] **Consent** You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

Settle who has the final say

- [ ] **Supermajority** A big decision needs more than a narrow win.
- [ ] **Unanimity** Every person must actively agree before you move.
- [ ] **Delegation** The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

We will try

This way, for this decision.

How did it feel?

Keep it, or try another?

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Twelve ways to decide

Choose the way before the discussion starts. Ask what this decision needs most: narrowing many options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say. Then pick one way from that group and write it on the canvas.

Narrow down options

Dot voting

How it works: Everyone places a few dots in one round. Then talk about the options at the top.

Use it when: A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.

Watch out: Popular isn't always right. Discuss the top options before you decide.

Multi-voting

How it works: Vote in rounds and drop the weakest option each time, until a shortlist remains.

Use it when: One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.

Watch out: It takes longer. Agree the number of rounds up front.

Scoring matrix

How it works: Rate each option against three to five agreed criteria, then compare totals and trade-offs.

Use it when: Every option has its own trade-offs.

Watch out: Agree the criteria before scoring, or people choose criteria that fit their favourite.

Decide quickly

Majority vote

How it works: One vote each. The option with more than half of the votes wins.

Use it when: There are two options and either would work.

Watch out: The losing side may not commit. Only use it when both options are acceptable.

Plurality

How it works: One vote each. The option with the most votes wins, even below half.

Use it when: There are several options and no time for more rounds.

Watch out: The winner may have less than half the room behind it.

Authority

How it works: One person hears from the people affected, then decides and explains why.

Use it when: One person is accountable for the outcome.

Watch out: Say up front that one person decides, and explain the decision afterwards.

Bring everyone along

Fist to five

How it works: Everyone shows zero to five fingers at the same time. Ask the lowest: what would raise your score by one?

Use it when: People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.

Watch out: Low scores need a conversation, not a new vote.

Consensus

How it works: Share a proposal, listen to concerns, adapt it, and check that everyone can back it.

Use it when: Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.

Watch out: Slow, and the most cautious person can block. Save it for decisions everyone must carry.

Consent

How it works: Ask for serious reasons not to try it. Resolve the valid objections, then go ahead.

Use it when: You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

Watch out: An objection needs a reason, a risk or harm, not just a preference.

Settle who has the final say

Supermajority

How it works: Agree a threshold, such as 75%, before voting. Go ahead only if you reach it.

Use it when: A big decision needs more than a narrow win.

Watch out: Set the threshold before the vote, never after.

Unanimity

How it works: Each person gives a clear yes or no. A single no sends the proposal back.

Use it when: Every person must actively agree before you move.

Watch out: One person can stop everything. Use it rarely.

Delegation

How it works: Choose who decides, and agree their mandate, limits and deadline.

Use it when: The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

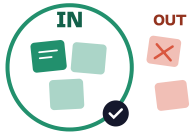
Watch out: Write the mandate down, and don't overrule the person afterwards.

Combine them: narrow down with dot voting, then decide by consent. Whatever you choose, agree who decides, who is asked first, and who is told afterwards.

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5 How do we want to be together?

The two-circle team contract



One behaviour per post-it, written so anyone could see it. Stick it in IN or OUT, then combine similar ones.

Whole team · 60 min

IN

Behaviour we practise and protect

OUT

Behaviour that undermines trust or good work

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6 How do we learn and reform?

Keep / Change / Try



One idea per post-it. Agree one small experiment, and what should make you sit down with the canvas again.

Whole team · 40 min

Keep

What should we protect?

Change

What is no longer helping us?

Try

What small experiment will we run next?

We sit down with the canvas again when...

For example: someone joins or leaves, or our purpose changes.

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